and political support allowed India to counter Pakistan and China. Globally, partnering with Moscow seemed an apt response to challenge the Americans too. Gandhi held the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA, the US external intelligence agency) responsible for her loss in the 1977 general elections.[43] Often feeding her incorrect information about America's anti-Indira stance, the KGB ensured Gandhi's dependence on Moscow.[44] The US, for its part, saw Gandhi's pro-Soviet tilt as R&AW-KhAD-KGB nexus against American interests.[45] Convincing adversaries of India's conciliatory and non-aligned intentions, in such a scenario, was impossible, and if not, then highly improbable.

Still, in June 1981, Rao visited Pakistan and went on to declare that India was 'unequivocally committed to respect Pakistan's national unity, territorial integrity, and sovereign equality' and its right to obtain arms for self-defense.[46] Speaking at the Pakistan Institute of International Affairs in Karachi on 11 June 1981, he added that 'we [India] have an abiding interest, even a vested interest, in the stability of Pakistan ... Our attitudes towards each other should freely evolve on the basis of our direct and clear perception of each other's interests and motivations, based on direct contacts and direct exchange of views. We should develop an individual and, if necessary, a joint capacity to resist the negative impact on us by external trends, external elements and extraneous factors'.[47] Even such outreach did not yield results. A shrewd politician, Zia offered a 'no war' pact instead and sought the withdrawal of 'at least two Indian divisions from its eastern borders' to make Pakistan feel 'sure' about Rao's (and previously Swaran Singh's) proposal.[48] Having already transformed the Afghan crisis into a strategic windfall, Zia's 'no-war' pact was aimed at blunting Gandhi's overtures. It would allow polishing Pakistan's image as a peace-loving country on one hand, but continue to build its arsenal on the other. Pakistan had already been offered a six-year US$ 3.2 billion aid package by Washington in 1981 that included forty F-16 fighter-bombers, and close to US$ 3 billion were funneled as military and economic assistance to the Mujahideen via the ISI.[49] India rebuffed the proposal. Only a comprehensive peace treaty made sense to New Delhi.

As hopes for a South Asian solution faded, Pakistan hosted the 11th Islamic Foreign Ministers Conference to develop a collective security plan for Muslim countries.[50] It was clear that neither would Pakistan give up the arms it was